



When algorithms sell: rethinking consumer behavior in the AI-enhanced marketplace

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Forget the glossy promises of hyper-personalization. The real story of AI in digital marketing isn't convenience, it's the quiet, systematic erosion of consumer agency, replacing genuine choice with a theater of options curated by profit-optimizing ghosts in the machine. We're not being served, we're being gamed, the stakes are nothing less than the autonomy of desire itself.

The core illusion peddled by “algorithmic selling” is neutrality. These systems, touted as objective efficiency engines, learning from every scroll, much like the deep learning recommenders dissected by Zhang et al. (2020), are anything but. They are meticulously designed to fulfill one master: shareholder value. When an Amazon recommendation nudges you toward privileged partners or a Spotify playlist subtly favors label affiliates, it's not serendipity—it's revenue engineering masquerading as service. The “tailor-made journey” touted by Gao and Liu (2023) as enabling need-matching is, in dominant platforms, a path pre-paved toward the checkout, systematically prioritizing need-creation for high-margin items over genuine discovery.

This is the colonization of cognitive space. The “abstracted customer”—defined by clickstreams and purchase histories—isn't a neutral data point. It's a deliberate reduction. Algorithms flatten the messy, irrational, context-rich tapestry of human motivation into a handful of quantifiable signals predictive of conversion. What gets lost? The impulse buy inspired by a friend's enthusiasm, the discovery of a local artisan buried beneath SEO-optimized giants, the choice driven by ethical conviction. The “dialogue” brands claim? It's a monolog delivered by code. While O'Sullivan and Shankar (2019) rightly note marketplace culture reflects our desires, the algorithm actively *shapes* those desires toward profitable ends, inverting the dynamic.

The insidious consequence is cultural atrophy. When algorithmic success is measured solely by clicks and conversions, *value* itself is redefined. Authenticity, craftsmanship, or community impact becomes secondary to “engagement metrics.” Witness the local bookstore's curated selection drowned out by Amazon's algorithm pushing bestsellers and sponsored spots. See platforms prioritize outrage-optimized content over nuance. The marketplace becomes an engine of homogenization, where what *sells* eclipses what *matters*.

Who holds the reins? Not marketers, constrained by algorithmic black boxes, but *platform architects and owners*. Their priorities—growth, engagement, and revenue—dictate the experience. Policy makers, mesmerized by “innovation,” fail to ask: innovation for *whom*? Funders demand scalable returns, pushing startups toward extractive data practices. This isn't neutral technology; it's a power structure disguised as efficiency.

We must transcend superficial debates about algorithmic bias and demand structural interventions: First, radical algorithmic transparency requires plain-language explanations for consumers, such as “You see this because buyers of X bought Y” or “Sponsored by Z”, rendering the invisible hand of profit-driven curation visible. Second, we must embrace friction as a design feature, mandating non-optimized discovery zones like “human-curated sections” or “local spotlights” to shatter filter bubbles and force algorithms to serve human curiosity, not just engagement metrics. Finally, regulating the optimization goal is critical infrastructure: policymakers must scrutinize *what* algorithms maximize, asking whether engagement should trump well-being, or profit eclipse fair competition, to rebuild the marketplace as a humane space.

The choice isn't Luddism or uncritical adoption. It's reclaiming the marketplace as a human space. Algorithms *can* serve discovery, but only if we dismantle their myth of neutrality and ruthlessly subordinate them to human values, not quarterly reports. Let's stop being optimized

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subjects and start demanding tools that serve genuine agency. The future of desire depends on it.

Curmudgeon Corner Curmudgeon Corner is a short opinionated column on trends in technology, arts, science and society, commenting on issues of concern to the research community and wider society. Whilst the drive for super-human intelligence promotes potential benefits to wider society, it also raises deep concerns of existential risk, thereby highlighting the need for an ongoing conversation between technology and society. At the core of Curmudgeon concern is the question: What is it to be human in the age of the AI machine?—Editor.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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